FREE BROCHURE

Sharing Images and the Law in Ireland

Plain facts about sharing images, what to do if an image is shared, how to say no, and where to get help.

WHO IT IS FOR

Autistic young people and adults, and the parents, carers, teachers and SNAs who support them.

NCCA STAGE

Junior Cycle · Senior Cycle and LCA · Adults

Easy read

Sharing a private image of someone without their say-so is a crime. If you are in trouble, tell an adult you trust. Help is free.

How to use this resource

- Read this together at a calm time. Take one section at a time. Each section starts with an **easy-read** box.
- Go through the scripts on page 5 and practise them out loud. Practice makes it easier to say no when it matters.
- Adults: read the notes for adults first. Stay calm and factual. The aim is safety, not fear.
- Keep this brochure where it can be found, and share it with anyone who supports the young person.

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Version 1.0 · sharing-images-law-ireland

1. Images and the law in Ireland

There are laws about images.

A private image is for the person in it.

Sharing it without their say-so is a crime.

Pictures and videos feel quick and easy to send. But in Ireland, some images are covered by serious laws. These are the main ones.

Coco's Law (2020)

The Harassment, Harmful Communications and Related Offences Act 2020 is known as **Coco's Law**. Under this law, it is a crime to **share, or threaten to share, an intimate image of someone without their consent**. The penalty can be up to **7 years in prison**. It does not matter why the person did it. Motive does not matter.

Images of anyone under 18

Under the **Child Trafficking and Pornography Act 1998**, making, having or sharing a sexual image of anyone under 18 is child sexual abuse material. This is true **even if the image is of yourself, or if the person agreed**. Schools and Gardaí focus on keeping young people safe and supported, but the law is serious.

Age of consent

In Ireland, the age of consent to sexual activity is **17**.

Do not forward the image to show an adult

If you have been sent an image of someone under 18, do not forward it, even to show a teacher or parent. Forwarding is sharing. **Tell the adult** what happened and show them the message on your own device if they ask.

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2. What to do if an image has been shared

Stop. Do not reply.

Tell an adult you trust.

Report it. You can get help.

If a private image of you, or of someone you know, has been shared, you did not do anything wrong by being upset. Here are the steps. You do not have to do them alone.

1

Do not forward it

Do not send it on to anyone, even to say how bad it is.

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2

Do not delete the evidence yet

Talk to an adult or the Gardaí first. Messages and the account name can help them.

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3

Tell a trusted adult

A parent, carer, teacher, SNA or the school's Designated Liaison Person.

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Report to the platform

Use the report button in the app. Ask for the image to be removed.

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5

Report at hotline.ie

Hotline.ie takes reports of intimate images shared without consent and of child sexual abuse material.

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6

Contact the Gardaí

Go to a Garda station, or call 112 or 999 in an emergency. You can ask an adult to go with you.

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You can also call Childline on 1800 66 66 66, text 50101 or chat at childline.ie if you are under 18, any time. Adults who need to talk can call the Dublin Rape Crisis Centre helpline on 1800 77 88 88.

3. If someone asks you for an image

You can always say no.

Nobody should ask for a private image.

Tell an adult you trust.

Someone might ask nicely. They might say everyone does it, or that it proves you like them. You never have to send an image. Saying no is a good choice. It is not rude.

Someone you like asks for a private photo.

No, I do not send those. Please do not ask again.

They keep asking.

I said no. I am stopping this chat now.

They say "if you really liked me you would".

Liking someone does not mean sending that. The answer is still no.

They say they will tell people if you do not.

I am telling an adult now. I am blocking you.

A friend asks you to send an image of someone else.

No. That is not mine to share.

You are not sure what to say.

I need to go. I will talk to you later.

You do not need to explain

You do not need a reason. You can say no, block the person, keep the messages and tell an adult. You can do that at any time, even if you said yes before.

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4. Sextortion: warning signs



Sextortion is blackmail with an image.



Never pay. Stop replying.



Tell someone. It is not your fault.

Sextortion is when someone threatens to share an intimate image unless you pay money, send more images or do what they say. Threatening to share an intimate image is also a crime under Coco's Law.

Warning signs

- Someone you have only met online is very friendly very fast, or says they are your age.
- They move the chat to a private app quickly.
- They send you an image first, and then ask for one back.
- They ask you to keep the chat a secret.
- They suddenly threaten to share an image unless you send money, gift cards or more images.

Never pay. Stop replying. Tell someone.

- **Never pay.** Paying does not make it stop. They usually ask for more.
- **Stop replying** and do not delete the chat yet. Take screenshots if an adult agrees, and keep the account name.
- **Block and report** the account on the platform.
- **Tell a trusted adult** and contact the Gardaí. It is **not your fault**. The person doing the blackmail is the one breaking the law.

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5. Where to report and get support

I want to…	Who to contact
Report an intimate image shared without consent, or child sexual abuse material	**hotline.ie**
Report on a game or app	The report button inside the app
Talk to someone under 18, any time	**Childline** 1800 66 66 66 · text 50101 · childline.ie
Text support any time	Text **HELLO** to **50808** (Text About It)
Report a crime or get Garda advice	Your local Garda station · **112 or 999** in an emergency · Garda Confidential Line 1800 666 111
Talk about sexual violence or abuse	**Dublin Rape Crisis Centre** 1800 77 88 88 (free, 24 hours)
Get online safety advice	**webwise.ie**
Tell the school	The Designated Liaison Person (DLP) or a trusted teacher

Notes for adults

- If a young person tells you about an image, **stay calm**. Say: "Thank you for telling me. You are not in trouble. We will sort this out together." Fear of getting in trouble is the biggest reason young people stay silent.
- Do not ask to see the image. Do not forward or copy it. Do not delete anything before you have spoken to the Gardaí. In school, tell the DLP the same day. Follow *Child Protection Procedures for Schools* (2023) and *Children First* (2017).
- Autistic young people may take rules literally, may find it hard to read intentions, and may be very trusting of someone who is kind or who shares their special interest. Teach the scripts. Practise them at a calm time.
- Be factual about the law. It is there to protect people. Gardaí and schools focus on safety and support for young people, but do not give the impression that nothing can happen.
- Talk about the other side as well. A young person who has been sent an image they did not ask for has not done anything wrong, but should not forward it.
- The age of consent is 17. Make sure the young person knows that being under 18 and sending images is still covered by child protection law, and that is why telling an adult matters.

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Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 3 **Relationships and Sexuality** and Strand 2 **Making Healthy Choices**: consent, respect, online safety and the law.
- Senior Cycle SPHE (new specification published 2024, being introduced for fifth years) and LCA Social Education.
- NCCA guidance on RSE for students with special educational needs: use plain language, visual supports and scripts.
- Department of Education Wellbeing Policy Statement and Framework for Practice (2018, updated 2019); *Child Protection Procedures for Schools* (2023).

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Hotline.ie

Report intimate images shared without consent, and child sexual abuse material, at hotline.ie. They can help get images removed.

An Garda Síochána

Contact your local Garda station, or 112 or 999 in an emergency. Garda Confidential Line: 1800 666 111.

Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

Rape Crisis Help

Dublin Rape Crisis Centre national helpline, free and 24 hours: 1800 77 88 88.

Webwise

Online safety advice for parents, teachers and young people at webwise.ie.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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